

Marianne Moore and American Calvinism: Sites of Struggle

“Sites of Struggle: Marianne Moore and American Calvinism.” *The Calvinist Roots of the Modern Era*, ed. Alik Barnstone, Michael Tomasek Manson, and Carol J. Singley. Hanover: The University Press of New England, 1997. 91-106.

Marianne Moore and the Calvinist tradition: for champions of Moore, the topic incites certain resistances. During the past decade or more, in the all-out effort at critical reclamation of Moore as a major modernist, her supporters have been willing (for the most part) to give the nod to the poet’s inarguably ethical sense of purpose. Yet they have as a rule avoided the word “Puritan,” which carries common, and commonly unfortunate, alliterative associations: piety, prudery, pedantry—together, perhaps, with the idea of a fatally dated, rather rigid politeness. After all, isn’t the *true* modernist marked (among other things) by skepticism; by a bold, frequently competitively bluff or *mano à mano* approach to sexual subject matter; by a disinclination for moral didacticism; and by a cleansing or salutary anti-Victorian anti-gentility? This question of the credentials for, and what we might call the conscience of, modernism is one to which I will return.

Opening the door of Moore criticism to the Calvinist inheritance—a rich and lasting *imaginative* inheritance, as Sacvan Bercovitch and others have pointed out ¹ (*American Puritan*)—need not make way for her modernist demotion. Rather, Moore’s brand of modernism and her traditional Presbyterian religiosity manage in an unusual way to brace and interanimate one another. Moore’s commitment or calling—or, as the Puritans would say, her “errand”—is at once spiritual and aesthetic. And this twofold purpose is specifically *American* in nature for the poet who sees, like a true pilgrim, opportunity in resistance and salvation in struggle. She

imbibed, after all, this dual sense of mission and these American Protestant ideals with her mother's milk.

In *Marianne Moore: Vision into Verse*, Patricia C. Willis's 1987 catalogue to a Rosenbach Museum & Library exhibition, I find a powerful visual emblem of Moore's combined Calvinist, modernist, and familial "errand." The Moore family owned an unsigned nineteenth-century American oil painting, *View of the Ohio River from above McKees Rocks* (37). At the lower right it portrays, on a wooded hill in western Pennsylvania overlooking the broad Ohio River, a mother and two children saying grace before their picnic lunch. This competent, pleasant work with its typical Hudson River-school perspective may be seen, like Moore's much more remarkable poetic *oeuvre*, as wonderfully linking private and public mythos, the Moore family condition and that family's perception of the manifest destiny of the nation.

A bit of biography is in order. On November 15, 1887, Marianne Craig Moore, the second child of Mary Warner Moore, was born into a fatherless household. Mary Warner, separated from John Milton Moore after his mental breakdown in the months before Marianne was born, had moved with her then year-old son, John Warner, into the Kirkwood, Missouri, parsonage of her Presbyterian minister father, John Riddle Warner. Mrs. Moore's insistence on the patronym "Warner" in both her own name and that of her son (whom she habitually addressed as Warner rather than John), as well as her bequeathment of her deceased mother's surname "Craig" to Marianne, suggests how fiercely she cleaved to the values and sense of self acquired in her childhood home. Mary Warner's devotion shows, too, in her posthumous publication, at some cost to herself, of the Reverend Warner's collected sermons—including the rather famous address he had delivered at Gettysburg, which at that time and place evidently rivaled Lincoln's for the attention it received (Molesworth 2).

When Reverend Warner died in 1893, Mrs. Moore took her two small children to live near Pittsburgh with her uncle Henry. When Henry in turn died in 1895, she then resettled in Carlisle, Pennsylvania. Fate had insistently and repeatedly erased from the picture, as we might say, any father figure for Marianne and her brother. It is clear why, then, the painting previously described must have had special resonance within Mary Warner's household: an isolated group of three with no adult male in view, huddled closely, dwarfed by and praying in the lush garden/wilderness of Pennsylvania.²

I have just imported into my discussion, as the reader may have noticed, traditional Calvinist terms for America: "garden" (the New World as Eden, or as the *hortus conclusus* of the redeemed soul) and "wilderness" (the Puritan settlers' experience as akin to the Exodus or other biblical ordeals or tests of spirit). Since the group in the painting is portrayed on a hill, that image may bring to mind as well the Puritans' typological figuring of America as the "City on a Hill" or New Jerusalem. In Moore's poetry and in the mythos of her family, such traditional terms do not seem artificially or anachronistically imposed, so deeply ingrained into both poetry and family psychodynamics is unswerving American Protestant purpose.

Just listen, for only two of many possible examples, to Mrs. Moore ardently reinstilling, in passages from two 1905 letters addressed to both of her now college-aged children; a sense of mission in peculiarly Puritan terms (Marianne then at Bryn Mawr, and Warner—nicknamed "Toady"—then at Yale):

Don't forget that we three are "a Peculiar people;" that is, acc. to the Scriptures, a people *set apart*. We have a mission in the world; as the old prophets used to call their message, "*a burden*," and it behooves us to carry it directly. As Jesus said about his mission to earth, "how am I straitened—until it be accomplished?" Never, dear Toady, forget that; more than to get teaching, more than to do well in athletics, more than to make pleasant friends, you have the burden of delivering to every soul with whom you come in contact, *the impress of the Lord Jesus*.

You are both out at sea now, and those who are in the harbor are full of anxiety—as to the gales you are called upon to weather. Were you in a different company of “your own people” I should know things with you to be wholly different. But you are as if young Cromwell and young Milton were taken up bodily and put down in the French Court, there to grow up. I pray the stamina may be in you to do as they would have done in such a case; for I think Milton would have come forth at last, the unsullied soul he pictured “the Lady” in *Comus*, to be, and Cromwell alike have come out unscathed; the valiant, the fighter of evil. (*Letters* 19 Oct., 23 Oct., 1905)

Of course, in the way high seriousness always invites deflating levity, these maternal sermons-in-miniature may carry somewhat comical moments for us, Mary Warner’s latter-day and unintended audience: the inconsonant address to Warner by his babyish nickname from *The Wind In The Willows*, for example;³ the straight-faced summoning of “unsullied” Milton—in his own day dubbed by his peers at Cambridge “the lady of Christ’s [College]” for his excessive nicety; or the xenophobic ruffling of feathers at those always decadent devils, the Catholic French!

Still, the Moore family correspondence is strangely poignant in what we can gather from it about the anacletic intensity of this little circle’s bonding in the face of felt vulnerability. In one letter, Mrs. Moore actually tells her children that although she herself has taken to writing extra notes to them, they need not feel obliged to contribute to more than the usual *two* round-robin letters each week. And the letters are striking, as we’ve just seen, in their reliance on Puritan tropes and types: Mrs. Moore’s typological identification of her family with the Old Testament Israelites (“a Peculiar people”); her likening of their family mission to that of the “old prophets” crying in the wilderness: her deployment of the twin role models, Milton and Cromwell; and, finally, her figuration of spiritual life as a battle and of her children’s college experience—echoing the Pilgrims’ Atlantic ordeal—as a hazardous sea voyage. John Warner’s and Marianne’s letters as well as their mother’s explicitly and implicitly subscribe to this mythos—as when Marianne, in a move meant to reassure her mother, refers to her own “stiff Puritan nature,”

or when she bucks freshman homesickness in battle terms: “No one has died of mere unhappiness and I will get over it sooner or later so why not now. But my philosophy seems almost vanquished sometimes” (*Letters* 14 Oct., 15 Oct., 1905).

The voluminous and lifelong correspondence of brother, sister, and mother attests to their shared Calvinist convictions that the path of the Elect must be hacked through the forest of adversity and that the Enemy, or Satan, lurks not only outside—in the hostile or indifferent or immoral world—but also inside, most balefully in the shape of that most dire sin: despair. The weapon they all wielded against disbelief and despondency was the written and spoken word. As Presbyterian minister and sometime navy chaplain, John Warner Moore, like his grandfather, wrote and delivered sermons. Mrs. Moore, a preserver of her father’s sermons, in Marianne’s youth taught English at a girls’ high school, and then later consistently commented on or even “corrected” her adult daughter’s poetic drafts. Marianne composed verse and stories from childhood, contributed wide-ranging and influential editorial “Comments” during her years at *The Dial* magazine (1921-1929), and authored, throughout her long life, some of the most idiosyncratic and shrewd literary letters ever penned.⁴ Most importantly, she created that unlikely—even apparently oxymoronic—article: an audaciously *modernist* religious poetry.⁵

What drives Moore’s indubitably modern poetry of spirit and permeates its subjects, tropes, and forms is a literary-*cum*-spiritual ethos of struggle—a complex drama of external and internal resistances that originates in orthodox Protestantism and, as we have seen, has been fervently privatized within the Moore family matrix. Struggle or resistance, variously contextualized, is the subject of virtually every Moore poem. “The Fish,” from her groundbreaking 1924 book, *Observations*, provides a particularly compact and memorable example. Here, Moore finds in an ocean-battered cliff an emblem of spiritual endurance:

All
 external
 marks of abuse are present on this
 defiant edifice—
 all the physical features of
 ac-
 cident—lack
 of cornice, dynamite grooves, burns, and
 hatchet strokes, these things stand
 out on it; the chasm-side is
 dead.
 Repeated
 evidence has proved that it can live
 on what can not revive
 its youth. The sea grows old in it.
 (*Complete Poems*, 26-40)

The poem, with its insistence on the values of fortitude and faith, is, as Andrew J. Kappel points out, one of Moore's "inspirational statements of a religious belief" (46). It is also, like so many of Moore's early works, a statement of her determination and artistic defiance. With its chiseled five-line verse units, "The Fish" has what John Hollander reminds us so many times of Moore's poems possess: the look of seventeenth-century lyric stanzas (88). And, in another Renaissance association, the word "hatchet," together with the punning linebreak on "ac-," may even recall those Protestant courtiers who defied "mere" physical execution on the scaffold: "What matter," said Walter Raleigh, consummate self-fashioner of his own legend, "how the head lie, so the heart be right" (qtd. in Greenblatt 29).⁶

Yet Moore's "The Fish," with its apparently arbitrary syllabic measure that leaves syllables or articles ("ac-," "an," "the") oddly stranded on individual lines, is not a Renaissance religious poem, after all; its doughtiness has a distinctly modern cast. For William Carlos Williams, Moore was a paragon of modern "scientific" writing with a sort of genius for surgery: "Miss Moore gets great pleasure from wiping soiled words or cutting them clean out, removing the aureoles that have been pasted about them or taking them bodily from greasy contexts" (87).

We are so used to thinking of modernist strategies in tandem with profound or postured religious skepticism that we may be baffled by this technically advanced poet who was so absolutely a believer and whose writing is, as her younger friend Elizabeth Bishop once wrote in “Invitation to Miss Marianne Moore,” “all awash with morals” (82-83).

But what if we learn to see—as Moore’s poetry so often asks us to see—with new eyes? What if, as I have been suggesting in these pages, we view Moore’s Presbyterian morality and her formal modernity not so much as conflicting, but rather as complementary? Her famous and famously collage-like deployment of quotations we could then allow owes something also to sermonic citation and to the writings of Protestant biblical commentators (Kappel 49). Her predilection for containing her material in neat, syllabically symmetrical stanzas might come to seem not only, as Hugh Kenner finds it, a sign of contemporary keyboard culture,⁷ but also evidence of participation in psalm-book culture. We might even see in Moore’s fastidious poetic patterning what Albert Gelpi locates in the strict stanzas and container-images of the Puritan poet Edward Taylor: a means of evoking the fixed limits within which all created beings labor, and a reminder that the lot of humankind is both to contain and be contained by God (38). And finally, that surgical slicing of syntax, so admired in Moore by Doctor Williams: might that appear to us not only in the guise of cool experimentalism, but also as a Protestant passion—like the Puritans’ rapt absorption in anagrams and acrostics—for uncovering or discovering in words hidden associations or latent truths? Here we might pause to look again at the final stanza of “The Fish.” Notice the way Moore has positioned “it can live” at the end of one line and “can not revive” at the end of the next: she has unearthed or dis-covered in riven syntax the Christian paradox of eternal life in death.

I would like to linger for a moment on that last point about Puritan anagrams and acrostics, both because such wordplay is inherently interesting and because the topic leads us to consider a fundamental Calvinist dilemma underlying Moore's choice of subject matter as well as her formal decisions. According to Roy Harvey Pearce, anagrams and acrostics, based on persons' names and generally in the form of elegies, were popular among the Puritans because they uniquely satisfied a Ramist poetics: "a poetics of discovery, of examining and stating, of coming upon, of laying open to view" (*Continuity* 34). In other words, the following early American anagram is based on the presumption that, jumbled somehow within the letters of a name, God had planted evidence of a man's nature or fate:

Thomas Dudley
ah! old, must dye

The Puritan elegist who sent this verse in 1605 to old Thomas was probably not expressing, in proleptically Freudian fashion, a wish that Dudley die; nor was the poet claiming the status, sinful within the Calvinist worldview, of clever creator. Instead, the author was pointing to something he or she had detected within that vast system of correspondences and linked analogies—all of them waiting to be sighted and then cited—which was God's creation. A 1693 dissection of Samuel Arnold's name, for example, revealed that it was time for him to "Leave old Arms." Lydia Minot's name yielded three deciphered truths for her 1667 elegist: "I di to Al myn," "I di, not my Al," and "Dai in my Lot." And, for a final seventeenth-century example, in Elizabeth Tompson's name a relative descried her departed spirit's joyful exclamation: "O I am blest on top" (Pearce, *Continuity*, 29). (Because the game has proved irresistible, here is an anagram on my name: "Jeer in red mirth." And, taking just one last turn, I will now—none too soon—conclude this digression, "Ere J. M. Di Therr-in.")

The previous paragraph may itself be seen as illustrating, albeit in a somewhat trifling way, the Calvinist dilemma to which it refers. The action of looking, or of attempting to look, *outside* oneself to find God-given *objective* or literal truths can revert so easily—as in my own anagrams—to plainly *subjective* activity: the self just playing around or showing off, the self projecting its own inescapable preoccupations or anxieties. This inevitable human tendency to manipulate, to project, to find only what we are looking for works against that other, self-effacing search for objective knowledge; for, as the Puritans saw it, God’s own Truth, hidden variously in His Word and world but available to be discerned. Summarizing the problem succinctly, Bercovitch writes: “The Puritan’s dilemma was that the way from the self necessarily led through the self” (*Puritan* 165).

Having sternly repudiated not only Catholic but also Anglican hierarchical systems of authority, the Puritan relied on the authority of the Bible alone, the doctrine of *sola scriptura*. This left every Puritan his or her own exegete, poring over Scripture to gain understanding. The discovery of truths in anagrams is an obvious analogue to this scriptural process. To rephrase the problem, if you were looking for truth outside yourself *with your own eyes and mind*, how could you be certain you had not misconstrued or contaminated the text in the process? The dilemma was felt most strongly by the Puritans, at the epicenter of radical Protestant reformation, but tremors were widely registered. Both this Protestant faith in Scripture and this indissociable suspicion of self-as-interpreter are captured, for example, in the seventeenth-century Anglican George Herbert’s couplet from “The Flower”: “Thy word is all/*if* we could spell” (156-57, italics mine).

Marianne Moore’s poetry is made out of the very stuff of the Puritan dilemma. Hers is a poetics of profound self-suspicion. It is also, *par excellence*, a poetics of the *text*. Moore was,

after all, a bookish poet, gathering exotic information and images from the library rather than (in the manner of her younger friend Elizabeth Bishop) from actual travel experiences. She kept tiny, fastidiously cross-indexed notebooks of useful phrases: scraps from the Bible, from her mother's conversation, from sermons she had heard and books and articles she had read. And as is well known, most of Moore's poetic subjects (her cat named "Peter," for example; her paper nautilus; or her armored anteater, the pangolin) are drawn from the Book of Nature, God's other book, whose importance was acknowledged by the Renaissance humanists and Puritans alike.⁸

When he was not staring into the abyss of damnation, even the fierce Puritan divine Jonathan Edwards, as Susan Howe points out, was wont to open this second book and read in peaceful contemplation: "God's excellency, his wisdom, his purity and love, seem to appear in every thing; in the sun, moon, and stars; in the clouds, and blue sky; in the grass, flowers, trees; in the water, and all nature..." (46). Edwards's choice of words is echoed in this psalm-like outburst from one of Moore's best and longest poems, "The Pangolin":

Sun and moon and day and night and man and beast
each with a splendor
which man in all his vileness cannot
set aside; each with an excellence!
(31-35)

What I am suggesting is that Moore's habitual, we might even say scriptural, study of words and of the created world rises directly out of her Calvinist inheritance and faith. Tirelessly, her poems scrutinize both nature and language, describing and deciphering "God's excellency, his wisdom."

It is a small step, within this scheme of things, from pointing out how words contain or resemble other words to pointing out, as Marianne Moore will also do, how creatures or things resemble other created things: how a swan possesses "maple-/leaflike feet" ("Critics and

Connoisseurs”) or an elephant “fog-colored skin” (“The Monkeys”); or how a cat can suddenly jump with “froglike accuracy” (“Peter”). The emphasis here, as in Puritan anagrammatics, is on self-effacing scrutiny and on the revelatory juxtaposition of found things. And Moore’s Puritan-like avoidance of subjectivity propitiously dovetails with modernist collage techniques and with the modern poet’s objectivist credo. Moore’s much-anthologized poem “Peter,” about a pet cat, particularly revels in this depersonalized descriptive strategy. Peter has whiskers “like porcupine quills,” a “prune-shaped head” and “alligator eyes”: strikingly odd images all, but all unimpeachably objective.

Yet even this latter poem, which takes what we might now call Moore’s Calvinist objectivism to an extreme, is always on the brink of reverting to the subjectivity that it resists. After all, Moore’s cat—who, we are informed, has a perfect right to “the disposition invariably to affront”—clearly does also stand for the defiant young poet herself. And even if the poem did not toy with personification as it does (by giving Peter a “disposition,” for example, or by conjuring up a cat who “does not regard the published fact as a surrender”), even then it would bear the unmistakable imprint of its author’s uniquely impersonal personality. In the end, Marianne Moore’s “Peter” might best be described as a poetic paradox: an expression of self-assertion that robustly resists self-assertion.

Moore, then, is not merely retooling selected Calvinist writing tropes and strategies for modern times. In all her best poetry she vividly encapsulates that same warfare between the forces of self-effacement and self-assertion with which the Puritans were obsessed. The bald, abstract expression of Moore’s more usually implicit and concretely embodied theme of psychic struggle may be found in a line from her much-contested World War II poem, “In Distrust of Merits”: “There never was a war that was not inward.”⁹ For a seventeenth-century Puritan

parallel, popular in its own time, here are the opening lines of George Goodwin's "Auto-Machia":

I sing my SELF; my *Civil Warrs* within;
The *Victories* I howrely lose and win;
The dayly *Duel*, the continuall Strife,
The *Warr* that ends not, till I end my life.
(Bercovitch, *Puritan* 19)

The very title of Goodwin's poem, from the Greek, means Self-Fight. And the poet's rhymed couplets work hard to contain the opposed forces of self-love and self-loathing, confidence and dejection, while managing at the same time to convey something of the constantly remustered energy and accompanying exhaustion that must have marked Puritan spiritual life.

We might pause for a moment to notice in "Auto-Machia" certain wide-ranging intertextual connections. Goodwin's lines glance backward at the martial imagery of John Donne's holy sonnets (and "dayly *Duel*" specifically recalls the alliterative title of Donne's most famous sermon, "Death's Duel"). More important for the purposes of this discussion, Goodwin's poem also uncannily presages American poetry to come: most obviously, Walt Whitman's *Song of Myself* (beginning, "I celebrate myself, and sing myself"); and more subtly, the centripetal verse of the mid-twentieth-century confessionals, since Goodwin claims as subject matter "my *Civil Warrs* within."

The American poetic future foreshadowed in a popular Puritan verse: this tells us something about the endurance in our poetry of inherited Calvinist concerns, however shape-shifting those concerns have proved to be. It also suggests, I think, something important about the American literary centrality of Marianne Moore, a writer who has too often been scoffed at—or what is perhaps worse, condescendingly smiled at—for writing non-mainstream poetry.¹⁰

Of course it is a long way from Goodwin's early American couplets to Moore's characteristic modernist syllabics; a long way from the Puritan poet's contained verse to the sprawl of Walt Whitman, or from "Auto-Machia" to the confessionalism of, say, "Skunk Hour." Yet the American obsession with "SELF" in the form of either self-celebration or self-excoriation continues to leave clear tracks. Not all of us, to be sure, come from Calvinist stock or share Marianne Moore's Presbyterian beliefs, as I myself do not. But American life and literature nevertheless remain inescapably shaped by the conflicts, still with us, out of which not so long ago the nation was born.

American Puritans were not only seekers of religious freedom who became, with history's usual bitter irony, themselves implicated in religious oppression: The Puritan enterprise was, in addition, every bit as material as it was spiritual. These people settled on and claimed as their God-given right physical terrain. Some would insist they were visionaries and brave settlers of a new world; others that they were the world's self-justifying plunderers, even rapists. The land was a site of brutal conflict for native Americans and Puritans alike. The former were slaughtered, pushed from their homes, robbed of their food-sources, exposed to cruel new diseases. The latter—threatened by starvation, by harsh weather and aggressive beasts, by gruesome Indian attack and captivity—felt themselves surrounded by a wilderness that was, as they variously described it, "howling, hideous, boundless, unknown, Satanic, wild, forlorn" (Bercovitch, *Puritan* 102). Conceived in linguistic terms, the Calvinist New World must include not only the words *spirit*, *wonder*, and *hope*, but also *matter*, *fear*, and *guilt*. As Susan Howe has remarked of Puritan New England, "Contradiction is the book of this place" (*My* 45).

In the terms of this discussion, the fraught and beleaguered beginnings of American nationhood might be seen as the individual Puritan's "Self-Civil-War" writ large. On the one

hand, the Puritan “errand” was to search for spiritual purity in a new world, attending always with an open-hearted and open-minded alertness to God’s secret signs. On the other hand, the group mission amounted to settling a punishing and inhabited terrain, putting one’s stamp upon it, enforcing one’s will. At the troubled heart, then, of the Puritan settlers’ endeavor were both prayer and plunder. In the beginning, there was the open heart, there was the closed fist.

This “Auto-Machia” or “Self-Fight” at the *fons et origo* of the national enterprise is the focus of one especially energized poem that Moore wrote after she moved with her mother to New York City in 1918. “New York,” first published in *The Dial* in 1921, begins by referring to that city as “the savage’s romance,” with those three words conjuring up at once precolonial America and the savagery of contemporary commerce. At its conclusion—with Moore’s characteristic penchant for the precision of negation—it arrives at an affirmative definition of New York (and, as is implied, of the New World) through a complex list of rejected alternative definitions:

It is not the dime-novel exterior,
Niagara Falls, the calico horses and the war-canoe;
it is not that “if the fur is not finer than such as one sees others wear.
one would rather be without it”—
that estimated in raw meat and berries, we could feed the universe;
it is not the atmosphere of ingenuity,
the otter, the beaver, the puma skins
without shooting-irons or dogs;
it is not the plunder,
but “accessibility to experience.”
(16-25)

In her notes to this poem, Moore scrupulously attributes that last quotation, “accessibility to experience,” to Henry James, a personal hero. That Moore would look to James as an exemplar of what it means to be American is telling in a number of ways, some importantly related to her Calvinist perspective. “Accessibility to experience” may have been a phrase

pieced together from a jacket blurb for a 1910 English edition of James's *The Finer Grain*, or it may (which seems more likely) later have been extracted whole from Dixon Scott's 1917 *Man of Letters*, which Marianne and her mother brought along with them on a trip to California in 1920—and from which Mrs. Moore copied down the following phrases:

The elder Henry James had a sunny loathing for the literal, caring for our spiritual decency supremely...All he cared to produce was that condition of character which his son calls "accessibility to experience." You were interested only when you were interested—your very conscience ought to work unconsciously—and so our Henry James was equipped for life without plundering it. (M. W. Moore 13)

Moore's poetic use of material first copied by her mother reconfirms our sense of the extraordinary, familial nature of this literary/spiritual venture; and it is in this shared quotation that we find "accessibility" opposed outright to the notion of "plunder."

Obviously, for Moore, to be an American artist meant to be spiritually receptive rather than materialistically acquisitive. But more than that, it had something to do with an individual's "condition of character" and with respect for personal idiosyncracies and tastes ("You were interested only when you were interested"). A Calvinist suspicion of subjectivity is counterpoised by an equal advocacy of individualism. This balance is part of what Moore sees embodied in James and what makes her claim, as the title of her 1934 essay, "Henry James as a Characteristic American," attests. At the end of this essay, Moore (who makes it a point in her critical writings to allow her subjects their individual voices) jigsaws together sundry quotations from James himself to complete her portrait of him:

Love is the thing more written about than anything else, and in the mistaken sense of greed. Henry James seems to have been haunted by awareness that rapacity destroys what it is successful in acquiring. He feels a need "to see the other side as well as his own, to feel what his adversary feels"; to be an American is not for him "just to glow belligerently with one's country." Some complain of his transferred citizenship as a loss; but when we consider the trend of his fiction and his uncomplacent denouements, we have no scruple about insisting that he was American: not if the American is, as he thought "intrinsically and actively ample...reaching westward, southward, anywhere,

everywhere,” with a mind “incapable of the shut door in any direction.” (*Complete Prose* 321-22)

Aside from suggesting Moore’s personal motive for avoiding matrimony, which she referred to (in her poem “Marriage”) as “This institution” (an institution, too often, alas, manifesting itself as “Love...in the mistaken sense of greed”), the quoted passage delineates Moore’s American aesthetics: broadly speaking, an imaginative open-door policy that avoids “rapacity.” That openness means respect for the individuality of others, effort expended “to feel what [one’s] adversary feels,” as well as room for personal idiosyncrasy, the freedom to follow one’s own nose. As Moore asserts in her 1958 essay on “Idiosyncrasy and the Technique,” once again calling on her American exemplar, “In saying there is no substitute for content, one is partly saying there is no substitute for individuality—that which is peculiar to the person (the Greek *idioma*). One also recalls the remark by Henry James: ‘a thing’s being one’s own will double the use of it’” (*Complete Prose* 514).

To interfere with or suppress individuality is to lose something of intrinsic value and potential usefulness, regardless of the necessary “Self-Fight.” For this reason, Moore all her life protected her own singularity (or *idioma*) and generously applauded that of others: “Blessed is the man,” she quotes from the first Psalm of David, “who does not sit in the seat of the scoffer” (*Complete Prose* 512). For the same reason she celebrated in her poetry the individual forms of animal life. And for this reason, also, Marianne Moore (together with her mother) ardently supported women’s suffrage. As evidence of her thinking on that last subject, here is a sentence she jotted down with evident approval from a speech by Professor Zeublin in 1915: “Suffrage is not a question of superiority or the lack of it; it is a question of personality, and that of the woman is as sacred as that of the man” (qtd. in Molesworth 56). In the end, then, although the

Calvinism of others may have lent itself to sexism and to the suppression of individuality, Marianne Moore's Calvinism recognizes any given personality as "sacred"—as much the proper focus of human admiration and study as any other manifestation of what Jonathan Edwards called "God's excellency, his wisdom."

I have called special attention to Moore's active feminism in this context because it is perhaps easy for us to presuppose any form of Calvinism as inimical to feminism. It may be tempting for contemporary feminist critics to view the Puritan fathers as an all-male police force, with hapless American women poets—Bradstreet and Dickinson, in particular—fleeing from their aggregated menace like earlier versions of those plucky cinematic outlaws Thelma and Louise. But strong poets have always owned astonishing survival tactics. And there are, as Wendy Martin in her book on Bradstreet, Dickinson, and Rich has pointed out, ways in which the Puritan inheritance actually lends itself to the feminist cause: "Although there is a dramatic contrast between the content of the feminist vision and the Puritan vision, it is instructive to understand that there are striking parallels in form and that these shared patterns are an important part of American culture...The pattern of protest and reform and this belief in regeneration and renewal—of the possibility of beginning again—is a prominent characteristic of much American psychological and social life" (*American* 7). What Moore does not lose sight of is that American "possibility of beginning again" of which Martin speaks—the same possibility that of course propelled the Puritan endeavor. The still-youthful New World for her remains more pliant than the Old. Like the mind. America may in this sense be seen as "an enchanted thing"; like the mind, it is "not a Herod's oath that cannot change" ("The Mind Is an Enchanting Thing").

Living in New York in the teens and twenties of this century, Marianne Moore was in the theater when the curtain rang up on American Modernism, and became herself a leading actor in

the play. Lending to that movement her own personality, her own unique and Calvinist-based aesthetic, she came up with a poetics whose particular “difficulty” (to use Eliot’s acid test for modernism) was also unique. It does not plunge us into the cold waters of nihilism, for one thing. Neither does it possess the difficulty—not infrequently come across in the work of Moore’s masculine compeers—of a self-promoting and reader-abusive abstruseness. Moore is, after all, the poet who let us know, in her poem “England,” that she *wished* to write “in plain American which cats and dogs can read!” Moore’s reader is not faced with the embarrassment of encountering the author’s amplified erotic angst or self-flagellation. Nor, finally—although citation is a specialty of Moore’s—is her reader forced by ostentatious allusiveness to become an unpaid researcher or source-hunter: quotations in Moore’s poems are generally meant to be taken as they are found, gaining little for her text by being restored to their original contexts.

Moore’s poems are, rather, difficult in that they ask us to become, together with their author, “actively ample”; to increase our “accessibility to experience”; to be capable of wonder without “rapacity.” In Moore’s “An Octopus,” for example, her frequently baffling yet breathtaking catalogue-poem about the Nisqually Glacier atop Mt. Rainier, a waterfall observed on the goat-inhabited heights seems freed not only from Newtonian Law, but also from the force of the poet’s own moral “gravity”: ¹¹

And farther up, in stag-at-bay position
as a scintillating fragment of these terrible stalagmites,
stands the goat,
its eye fixed on the waterfall which never seems to fall—
an endless skein swayed by the wind,
immune to the force of gravity in the perspective of the peaks.
(54-59)

Returning to the Moore family’s nineteenth-century painting with which this essay began, allow me fancifully to propose that when reading Moore’s modernist poetry we are in

imagination located with her on that gentler promontory, the hill overlooking the Ohio River—at the time of the painting, as Patricia C. Willis reminds us, “the gateway to the west.” Not all of us share Moore’s conception of the sites (or sights) of struggle, in which spiritual warfare or the “daily *Duel*” holds out the hope of Christian salvation. Even so, we can comprehend such struggle as she proposes, and certainly without needing to categorize her effort as minor or unmodern for vocalizing an important set of American beliefs. It should be remembered that “modernism” now is as “modernism” is taught in English department classrooms, in which too often too little is understood of American cultural history, the history of ideas and of religion. To know Moore well is to become familiar with these disciplines, and to become avid in general for expanded understanding. As Moore said when she received the M. Carey Thomas Award of her alma mater, Bryn Mawr College, in June of 1953: “the test of culture is the ability to pay voluntary attention” (qtd. in Molesworth 360).

Notes

¹ As Bercovitch explains: “the Puritan legacy to subsequent American culture lies not in theology or logic or social institutions, but in the realm of the imagination” (*American Puritan* 7).

² Marianne Moore’s paternal grandfather, Captain William Moore, piloted and owned, with his brother, the steamer *Hope*, which plied the Ohio and Mississippi Rivers before the Civil War: thus an ancestral male figure is suggested by, although absent from, the painting. (Marianne Craig Moore, letter to the author, July 8, 1993). Ms. Moore also informed me that she and her sister recall seeing the painting in question in the living room of their grandmother’s and aunt’s apartment at 260 Cumberland Street in Brooklyn.

³ Following this *Wind In The Willows* nicknaming, Mrs. Moore was Mole, and Marianne Rat.

The close-knit family was addicted to pet names, and there were others: “Nunky” for Marianne, “Weaz” for John Warner, “Bunny” or “Bunny Long Ears” for Mrs. Moore, and so forth.

⁴ A volume of *The Selected Letters of Marianne Moore* is in progress: general editor, Bonnie Costello; associate editors, Cristanne Miller and Celeste Goodridge.

⁵ For a discussion of Moore’s Presbyterianism as it relates to her modernism, see Kappel.

⁶ Raleigh’s remark was in response to a member of the crowd who suggested that he ought to face the east, with its traditional association of resurrection (Greenblatt 29).

⁷ Kenner writes, “the words on these pages [of Moore’s poems] are little regular blocks, set apart by spaces, and referable less to the voice than to the click of the keys and the ratcheting of the carriage” (*Homemade* 98).

⁸ I discuss Moore’s deployment of the Book of Nature in relation to Renaissance prose writers, and particularly the prose of Sir Thomas Browne, in the first chapter of *An Enabling Humility*.

⁹ For a discussion of the contention surrounding this poem, and particularly the critique of Randall Jarrell, see Susan Schweik, chapter 1.

¹⁰ Roy Harvey Pearce is particularly virulent in his support of the *masculine* mainstream: “It might well be that there will be no American poetry in the next half-century, that it will be a new international poetry, deriving from a sense of the do-or-die community of men. Whatever else, it must surely be a poetry of *men*: men conceived as in their history representing the infinite range of possibilities of being and acting open to them when they realize that as man they are nothing if not men” (*Continuity* 433).

¹¹ Moore visited Mt. Rainier in Washington with her mother and brother in July of 1922, sightseeing and clambering on the mountain whose topmost meadow was called “Paradise.” For

the family of three, who had not been reunited since John Warner had gone to sea as a navy chaplain in 1917 and who had long held to a special sense of shared religious mission, this western vacation was highly charged, nearly allegorical.